

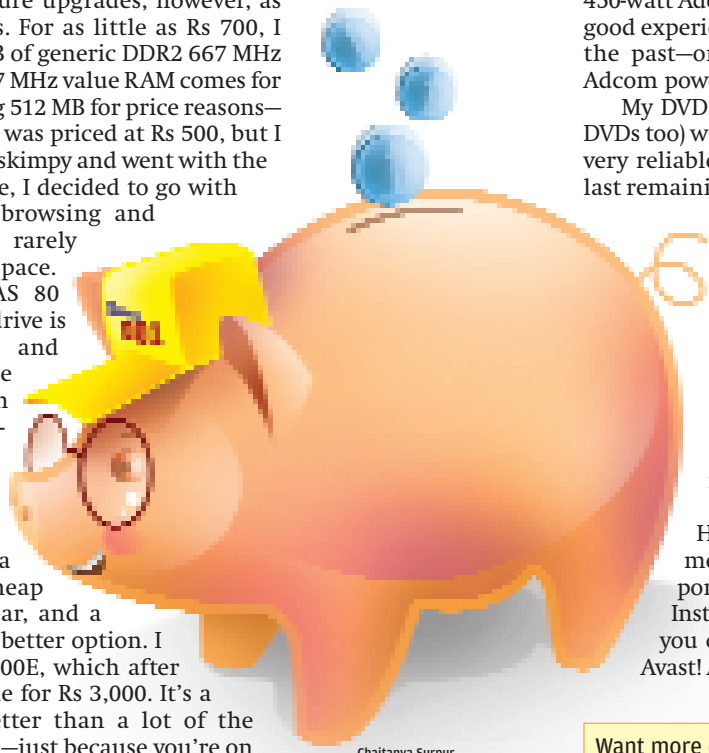
Computing For Everyone

I'm looking for the cheapest (respectable) PC configuration I can get my hands on

This is for the reader who e-mailed me recently—he was finally building his first PC after a number of years of reading *Digit*. He had a very modest budget, and wanted something that would *work*—allow him to use MS Office, and run Windows XP. I decided to build a *good* PC from scratch, for those on a very tight budget. At the same time, I want some sort of future-proofing—after all, we all know how most users expand their applications for the PC after a few months of use.

I took a trip to Lamington Road last week to check what I could come up with. I was surprised to find single-core processors totally out of stock with most vendors. Dual-cores have well and truly gone mainstream, with the best deals being combo packs. I was faced with two options—the Intel E2140 processor and Intel D945G motherboard is available for Rs 5,350, while AMD's 4000+ CPU is available on a Jetway GeForce 6100 for Rs 100 more. Both processors have comparable performance, but the AMD 4000+ is a little snappier than the E2140, which is a severely cut down Allendale core (Core 2 family). I went for Intel, mainly because the E2140 (1.6 GHz stock) is a very cool product, and overclocks very, very well, and runs very cool at stock. The 945G comes with onboard graphics—a boon for a value PC that doesn't require a graphics card. There is an x16 PCIe slot for future upgrades, however, as well as two PCI slots. For as little as Rs 700, I could get myself 1 GB of generic DDR2 667 MHz RAM; Transcend's 667 MHz value RAM comes for Rs 850. I was thinking 512 MB for price reasons—Transcend (667 MHz) was priced at Rs 500, but I decided not to be too skimpy and went with the 1 GB. For a hard drive, I decided to go with 80 GB, since basic browsing and office work will rarely require significant space. Seagate's ST380815AS 80 GB, 7200 rpm SATA drive is priced at Rs 1,500 and comes with a three year warranty, with doorstep replacement—hassle free.

With my core components chosen, I was at a loss deciding between a CRT and an LCD. Cheap LCDs aren't very clear, and a value CRT is a much better option. I chose a 15-inch LG 500E, which after bargaining a bit came for Rs 3,000. It's a nice screen, and better than a lot of the cheaper CRTs around—just because you're on a budget doesn't mean your eyes should suffer,



Chaitanya Surpur

Here's my Ultimate Value PC:		
Component	Model No	Price
CPU + Motherboard	Intel E2140 (1.6 GHz) + Intel D945G	Rs 5,350
RAM	1 GB Transcend Value DDR2 667	Rs 850
HDD	Seagate ST380815AS 80GB SATA	Rs 1,500
Monitor	LG E500 15" CRT	Rs 3,000
Keyboard + Mouse	Logitech multimedia combo with optical mouse	Rs 550
Cabinet	Zebronics Krish	Rs 950
Power Supply	Adcom 450 watts	Rs 700
Optical Drive	Liteon LH20-A1H 20x DVD Writer	Rs 1,350
Speakers	Creative Inspire 245 2.0	Rs 750
Grand Total		Rs 15,000

right? A multimedia keyboard and optical mouse from Logitech was available for Rs 550—sweet! Next, I went cabinet shopping. I saw a few cabinets from the likes of iBall, Zebronics, VIP and Intex, but didn't like any of the designs. After browsing a couple of catalogues at a few vendors, I came across a value series cabinet from Zebronics called Krish—a neat-looking box decked in black with cooling features like a PCIe vent and CAG duct. Best of all expansion, is good with three external 5.25-inch bays; at Rs 950, this was a must-buy.

For the power supply, I couldn't find anything decent below Rs 1,000 till I came across a 450-watt Adcom power supply for Rs 700. I've had good experiences with Adcom power supplies in the past—one of my old download rigs used Adcom power for over three years.

My DVD writer (yes, budget PCs get to burn DVDs too) was a Liteon LH20-A1H, a 20X burner—very reliable, very cheap, and just Rs 1,350. My last remaining component was a set of speakers;

I decided on a non-woofer setup, since speakers can always be upgraded if better music performance is needed later. Creative's Inspire 245 is a gorgeous looker, and at Rs 750, a good deal.

Finally, after six hours and three shops, I've got a PC that will happily run all essential applications, and will even allow moderate multimedia usage—all for just Rs 15,000!

A genuine copy of Windows XP Home OEM costs Rs 3,900. I recommend an original copy for the tech support you can avail of if things go wrong. Instead of shelling out for more software, you can find free essential software like Avast! Antivirus on our CDs every month. ■ agent001@thinkdigit.com

Want more of Agent 001? Turn over to read his answers to your buying questions

Dream Come True

I have put together my dream gaming rig after quite a lot of research: ASUS P5E3 Deluxe, Intel Q6700, Corsair TWIN3X2048-1333C9 G, ASUS GeForce EN8800GT 512MB, Samsung SpinPoint T166 HD321KJ, Lite-On DH-20A3S DVD writer, CoolerMaster eXtreme Power 600W PSU, Antec TX1088AMG cabinet, Logitech G5 Laser mouse, Microsoft Natural Ergonomic Keyboard 4000. But all this performance comes down to the screen I'm using. Please suggest the one with the best performance in the 20 to 22-inch size category. My budget is Rs 15,000 to 16,000. Also, comment on the above configuration and suggest any improvements.

Reuben "Re. J" James

Firstly, your system is very good, and a true gaming rig—congrats! Secondly, I suggest a 22-inch monitor for that budget. Look at Dell's E228WFP or BenQ's FP222W—two of the better panels I've come across. If you must go 20-inch then the Dell SP2008WFP is a very good buy.

Reviving An Ancient Rig

I want to buy a new motherboard which supports an old 478-pin Intel Pentium 4 processor, and 512 MB DDR RAM at 333 MHz. I also want a 256 MB graphics card and an SMPS (for gaming) in same budget even if the performance increment is mediocre. Help!

Sumit Lal

An upgrade would still leave you well behind the hardware curve, and enjoying most year-old games would be well beyond your setup. DDR memory is still available, but the price would be around double the price of DDR2 memory, simply because nobody is manufacturing DDR anymore. Assuming your motherboard even has an AGP slot you're out of luck, unless you manage to find an older GeForce FX5200/5500 or a 6200 graphics card. What I suggest is a complete upgrade after some saving up. Invest in a DDR2-based rig and a Core 2 Duo processor and you'll be well set for another two years or so. You'll also have a plethora of powerful and affordable PCIe graphics cards to choose from.

Beyond Onboard

Hi, I have an AMD Athlon 64 X2 4000+ Processor with an MSI K9N6GM (NVIDIA GeForce 6100) motherboard, 2 GB of DDR2 800 Mhz RAM and Windows Vista Home Premium. I am not satisfied with the graphics performance. I can't run games like *NFS Pro Street* or *Call Of Duty 4*. Can you please recommend a good NVIDIA GeForce graphics card? My budget is Rs 4,000 to 5,000.

Sumith Mohan

I suggest you save up a bit more and invest in an 8600GT-based card—its performance far surpasses the 8400GS and 8500GT chipsets which are priced around your budget. The 8600GT is a *real* mid-range offering, unlike the 8400GS and 8500GT which are meant more for powerful HTPCs rather than gaming setups.

The ASUS EN8600GT costs around Rs 7,000, and is terrific for the price.

Sight And Sound

I need a PCI Express graphics card, and my budget is Rs 10,000. I am also planning to buy a good set of headphones for Rs 1,000. What can I get for that budget?

Anonymous

For Rs 12,000, you can swing a sweet deal—an 8800GT-based card which will satisfy all your gaming needs. A whole lot cheaper is the 8600GT (Rs 7,000) chipset but this is also around 250 per cent slower. Creative's EP630 are in-ear plugs available for Rs 900 and deliver outstanding sound for the price. Among the larger circum-aural sets, the Sennheiser HD201 is available for around Rs 1,400.

Finally!

I have saved a little bit, and finally want to go for the long-pending dream—my own desktop PC. My budget is about Rs 40,000 (keeping away Rs 5,000 for Windows Vista). This includes everything, literally (what I mean is, the motherboard, processor, graphics card, DVD writer, cabinet, monitor, mouse, keyboard, SMPS, UPS, speakers). My main purpose would be movies and games. Although I know the budget does not suffice for the aforementioned, please suggest whatever you can. I want to play *Far Cry*, *Prince of Persia—The Two Thrones*, etc. But, if somehow *Crysis* runs on it, I'll be thrilled!

After taking into consideration the Zero1 Awards I have zeroed on the following:

- 1) Hard Drive—Western Digital Caviar SE16 WD3200AAKS 320 GB
- 2) Graphics Card—ASUS EN8600GT

Please, don't tell me to expand my budget much. The reason is simple, I can't. Also, I can wait for another month or two if necessary. So, if there is a probable price slash looming ahead...

Koustav Bhattacharya

Rs 40,000 is a good budget, although keeping in mind you also want to buy Vista you'll have just 35,000. Why not keep your hardware budget at Rs 40,000?

The ASUS EN8600GT is a very good card, and you can't go wrong there. For the hard drive, I recommend the new Seagate 250 GB 7200.10 series, which is a single-platter drive and costs Rs 2,800 now. It's a superb buy and is blazingly fast, too. ■

Ask Away!

Want a tech product, but don't know how to go about buying it? E-mail agent001@thinkdigit.com with your complete contact details, and he might answer them here! Please note that Agent001 only answers purchase-related questions in this space.

Agent 001's Recommendation		Price
Processor	Core 2 Duo E6550	Rs 6,400
Motherboard	Galaxy 650i LT	Rs 4,800
RAM	2 x 1 GB Transcend DDR2 667	Rs 2,200
Graphics Card	ASUS EN8600GT	Rs 7,000
HDD	Seagate 7200.10 250 GB—single platter disk	Rs 2,800
Monitor	Dell E198WFP 19" LCD	Rs 11,000
Keyboard + mouse	Logitech	Rs 500
Cabinet	Zebronics / VIP	Rs 2,000
SMPS	VIP 500W	Rs 2,000
Total		Rs 38,700